

BEFORE

While the last few emperors of the Ming dynasty were distracted by internal rebellion, a new power was gathering in the north.

THE JURCHEN BANNERS

The Jurchen people were descended from the founders of the Jin dynasty << 163. By the 16th century the Jurchen were living near Jilin in modern-day northeast China, where they hunted, farmed, and traded extensively with the Chinese. In 1616, the Jurchen leader **Nurhaci** founded the Later Jin dynasty and began to organize his people, as well as the Mongols and Chinese who had submitted to Jurchen rule. The entire population were enrolled into **four military units** called banners, each being identified by the color of their standards.

300 Jurchen families were formed into one *niru*, or company.

25 *niru*, or 7,500 families, were organized under one banner.

FROM JURCHEN TO MANCHU

Nurhaci's successor, Huang Taiji, introduced Chinese-style institutions among the Jurchen. In 1636 he changed the name of his people to Manchu (a word of unknown origin) and in 1637 renamed the Later Jin dynasty, adopting the dynastic name **Qing**, meaning "clear." The banner system was expanded by the conquests of Huang Taiji to include eight Manchu, eight Mongol, and eight Chinese banners by 1644.

By the early 17th century, the Ming dynasty (see pp.166–67) was beset by internal popular

rebellions and the threat of a Manchu invasion. In April 1644, the rebel leader Li Zicheng took Beijing, and the Ming emperor committed suicide. Li tried to persuade Wu Sangui, the most powerful commander on the frontier, to join him. Instead Wu negotiated with the Manchus, allowing them to pass freely through the Great Wall. The Manchus took control of Beijing in June and Li Zicheng fled.

Fulin, the six-year-old son of Huang Taiji (see BEFORE), became the Shunzhi emperor, thus inaugurating the Qing dynasty (1644–1911).

The Manchus continued their advance south, crushing any resistance from Ming loyalists. They also ordered all

male Chinese to show that they submitted to Qing rule by shaving their foreheads and adopting the queue, a long braided ponytail, which was compulsory in China throughout the Qing period.

Having gained control over China, the Qing instituted a bureaucracy that relied on features retained from the Ming administration, which included the system of government examinations. Few

Manchu could speak Chinese, and even fewer had any experience of office, so all senior posts within the bureaucracy were assigned to both a



Imperial Poetry

Emperor Kangxi was an accomplished poet as well as a sponsor of the arts. The poetry in this album is attributed to him.

Manchu and a Chinese official, a policy that helped somewhat in easing the resentment felt by the Chinese at being ruled by alien invaders.

The Prosperous Age

Shunzhi showed great promise as a ruler, but he died of smallpox at an early age. It was his three successors who were responsible for consolidating Qing power in China.

Shunzhi's son, the Kangxi emperor, was the longest-reigning emperor in Chinese history. Though born a Manchu, Kangxi became the epitome of a Chinese emperor. He read and commented on

The Three Emperors

The reigns of the Three Emperors, Kangxi (1661–1722), Yongzheng (1722–35), and Qianlong (1736–95), are known collectively as the “Prosperous Age,” a period when the Chinese empire expanded to its greatest extent and its population doubled.



more than 50 memorials every day, and traveled extensively. He was a patron of the arts and encouraged scholarship. During his reign he crushed a major internal rebellion and led successful campaigns against the Zunghar people of Mongolia.

Emperor Yongzheng, who may have usurped the throne, succeeded Kangxi. Yongzheng insisted on the use of the Manchu language at court and raised the salaries of officials to discourage corruption. To ensure ideological conformity he ordered that the Sacred Edict, which exhorted subjects to revere the emperor, be read out twice a month at Confucian temples.

The reign of the fourth Qing emperor, Qianlong (see right), saw the boundaries of China reach their farthest extent (see left). The addition of territory led to an expansion of the economy, as well as a significant population increase.

Missionaries

The first Christian Jesuit mission in Beijing had been established in 1598. When the Manchus came to power, they continued the Ming practice of

